

“The First Year of My Life”

Muriel Spark

Muriel Spark was born in Scotland in 1918 and educated in Edinburgh. Spark lived and wrote in Scotland, England, the United States, Zimbabwe (called Rhodesia at the time), and Italy, where she lived for more than thirty years. She died at home in Tuscany in 2006. Author of more than twenty novels and many volumes of stories, she is well known not only for her fiction but also for her poetry and nonfiction. A satirist, Spark targets hypocrisy with an acerbic tongue and sarcastic bite. Spark was born during the First World War, as she reveals in “The First Year of My Life,” and worked in British Intelligence during World War II. Both wars influenced the writing of the story below.

I was born on the first day of the second month of the last year of the First World War, a Friday. Testimony abounds that during the first year of my life I never smiled. I was known as the baby whom nothing and no one could make smile. Everyone who knew me then has told me so. They tried very hard, singing and bouncing me up and down, jumping around, pulling faces. Many times I was told this later by my family and their friends, but, anyway, I knew it at the time.

You will shortly be hearing of that new school of psychology—or maybe you have heard of it already—which, after long and far-adventuring research and experiment, has established that all of the young of the human species are born omniscient. Babies, in their waking hours, know everything that is going on everywhere in the world; they can tune in to any conversation they choose, switch on to any scene. We have all experienced this power. It is only after the first year that it is brainwashed out of us, for it is demanded of us by our immediate environment that we grow to be of use to it in a practical way.

It is not a new theory. Poets and philosophers, as usual, have been there first. But scientific proof is now ready and to hand. Perhaps the final touches are being put to the new manifesto¹ in some cell² at Harvard University. Any day now, it will be given to the world, and the world will be convinced.

Let me, therefore, get my word in first, because I feel pretty sure, now, about the authenticity of my remembrance of things past. My autobiography, as I very well perceived at the time, started in the very worst year that the world had ever seen so far. Apart from being born bedridden and toothless, unable to raise myself on the pillow or utter anything but farmyard squawks or police-siren wails, I was further depressed by the curious behavior of the two-legged animals around me. There were those black-dressed people, females of the species to which I appeared to belong, saying they had lost their sons. I slept a great deal. Let them go and find their sons. It was like the special pin for my nappies,³ which my mother, or some other hoverer dedicated to my care, was always losing. These careless women in black lost their husbands and their brothers. Then they came to visit my mother and clucked and crowed over my cradle. I was not amused.

“Babies never really smile till they’re three months old,” said my mother. “They’re not *supposed* to smile till they’re three months old.”

My brother, aged six, marched up and down with a toy rifle over his shoulder:

¹ A declaration of principles.

² A small group forming a unit of a larger organization.

³ The British term for diapers.

The grand old Duke of York
He had ten thousand men;
He marched them up to the top of the hill
And he marched them down again.

And when they were up, they were up,
And when they were down, they were down,
And when they were neither down nor up,
They were neither up nor down.

“Just listen to him!”
“Look at him with his rifle!”

I was about ten days old when Russia stopped fighting. I tuned in to the Czar,⁴ a prisoner, with the rest of his family, since evidently the country had put him off his throne and there had been a revolution not long before I was born. Everyone was talking about it. “Nothing would ever induce me to sign the treaty of Brest-Litovsk,”⁵ the Czar said to his wife. Anyway, nobody had asked him to.

At this point, I was sleeping twenty hours a day to get my strength up. And, from what I discerned in the other four hours a day, I knew I was going to need it. The Western Front,⁶ on my frequency, was sheer blood, mud, dismembered bodies, blistering crashes, hectic flashes of light in the night skies, explosions, total terror. Since it was plain I had been born into a bad moment in the history of the world, the future bothered, unable as I was to raise my head from the pillow and as yet only twenty inches long. “I truly wish I were a fox or a bird,” D. H. Lawrence was writing to somebody. Dreary old creeping Jesus. I fell asleep.

Red sheets of flame shot across the sky. It was the twenty-first of March, the forty-ninth day of my life, and the German spring offensive⁷ had started before my morning feed. Infinite slaughter. I scowled at the scene, and made an effort to kick out. But the attempt was feeble. Furious, and impatient for some strength, I wailed for my feed. After which I stopped wailing but continued to scowl.

The grand old Duke of York
He had ten thousand men...

They rocked the cradle. I never heard a sillier song. Over in Berlin and Vienna, the people were starving, freezing, striking, rioting and yelling in the streets. In London, everyone was bustling to work and muttering that it was time the whole damn business was over.

The big people around me bared their teeth; that meant a smile; it meant they were pleased or amused. They spoke of ration cards⁸ for meat and sugar and butter.

⁴ Nicholas II, the last czar of Russia, who was forced from power in the Russian Revolution of 1917.

⁵ The treaty—signed on 1918 March 3—by which the new Communist government of Russia made peace with Germany, withdrawing from World War I eight months before its end.

⁶ A 450-mile-long battlefield across Belgium and northeastern France, along which the Allies and Germany were locked in bloody trench warfare from 1914 to 1918.

⁷ In late March 1918, after its peace treaty with Russia ended fighting on the eastern front, Germany began a major push to win the war on the western front.

⁸ Cards entitling bearers to limited amounts of certain foods and other goods that were in short supply during the war.

"Where will it all end?" they asked.

I went to sleep. I woke and tuned in to Bernard Shaw,⁹ who was telling someone to shut up. I switched over to Joseph Conrad,¹⁰ who, strangely enough, was saying precisely the same thing. I still didn't think it worth a smile, although it was expected of me any day now. I got on to Turkey. Women dressed in black huddled and chattered in their harems. Yak-yak-yak. This was boring, so I came back to home base.

In and out came and went the women in British black. My mother's brother, dressed in his uniform, cam coughing. He had been poison-gassed in the trenches. "*Tout le monde à la bataille!*"¹¹ declared Marshal Foch,¹² the old swine. He was now Commander-in-Chief of the Allied Forces. My uncle coughed from deep within his lungs, never to recover but destined to return to the front. His brass buttons gleamed in the firelight. I weighed twelve pounds by now; I stretched and kicked for exercise, seeing that I had a lifetime before me, coping with this crowd. I took six feeds a day and kept most of them down by the time the *Vindictive* was sunk in Ostend Harbor,¹³ on which day I kicked with special vigor in my bath.

In France, the conscripted¹⁴ soldiers leapfrogged over the dead on the advance and littered the fields with limbs and hands, or drowned in the mud. The strongest men on all fronts were dead before I was born. Now the sentries used bodies for barricades and the fighting men were unhealthy from the start. I checked my toes and my fingers, knowing I was going to need them. *The Playboy of the Western World*¹⁵ was playing at the Court Theatre in London, but occasionally I beamed over to the House of Commons,¹⁶ which made me drop off gently to sleep. Generally, I preferred the Western Front, where one got the true state of affairs. It was essential to know the worst, blood and explosions and all, for one had to be prepared, as the Boy Scouts said. Virginia Woolf yawned and reached for her diary. Really, I preferred the Western Front.

In the fifth month of my life, I could raise my head from my pillow and hold it up. I could grasp the objects that were held out to me. Some of these things rattled and squawked. I gnawed on them to get my teeth started. "She hasn't smiled yet?" said the dreary old aunties. My mother, on the defensive, said I was probably one of those late smilers. On my wavelength, Pablo Picasso¹⁷ was getting married, and early in that month of July the Silver Wedding of King George V and Queen Mary was celebrated in joyous pomp at St. Paul's Cathedral. They drove through the streets of London with their children. Twenty-five years of domestic happiness. A lot of fuss and ceremonial handling over swords went on at Guildhall where the King and Queen received a check for over fifty-three thousand pounds to dispose of for charity as they thought fit. *Tout le monde à la bataille!* Income tax in England had reached six shillings in the pound. Everyone was talking about the Silver Wedding, and ten days later the Czar and his family, now in Siberia, were invited to descend to a little room in a basement. Crack, crack went the guns;

⁹ George Bernard Shaw, an Irish-born British playwright and social critic.

¹⁰ A Polish-born British novelist.

¹¹ *French*: The whole world into the battle!

¹² Ferdinand Foch, a French general who in March 1918 became commander of Allied forces on the western front.

¹³ In May 1918, a crew of Allied volunteers sunk the ship *Vindictive* to block the entrance of the harbor of Ostend, Belgium, which the Germans had been using as a submarine base.

¹⁴ Drafted into military service.

¹⁵ A controversial drama by Irish playwright John Millington Synge.

¹⁶ The lower house of the British parliament.

¹⁷ A Spanish painter and sculptor.

screams, and blood all over the place, and that was the end of the Romanoffs.¹⁸ I flexed my muscles. "A fine healthy baby," said the doctor, which gave me much satisfaction.

Tout le monde à la bastaille! That included my gassed uncle. My health had improved to the point where I was able to crawl in my playpen. Bertand Russell¹⁹ was still cheerily in prison for writing something seditious about pacifism. When I tuned in, as usual, to the front lines, it looked as if the Germans were winning all the battles yet losing the war. And so it was. The upper-income people were upset about the income tax at six shillings a pound. But all women over thirty got the vote. "It seems a long time to wait," said one of my drab old aunts, aged twenty-two. The speeches at the House of Commons always sent me to sleep, which was why I missed, as the actual time, a certain oration by Mr. Asquith²⁰ following the Armistice on November 11th.²¹ Mr. Asquith was a greatly esteemed former Prime Minister, later to be an earl, and had been ousted by Mr. Lloyd George.²² I clearly heard Asquith, in private, refer to Lloyd George as "that damned Welsh goat."

The Armistice was signed, and I was awake for that. I pulled myself onto my feet with the aid of the bars of my cot. My teeth were coming through very nicely, in my opinion, and well worth all the trouble I was put to bringing them forth. I weighed twenty pounds. On all the world's fighting fronts, the men killed in action or dead of wounds numbered 8,538,315 and the warriors wounded and maimed were 21,219,452. With these figures in mind, I sat up in my high chair and banged my spoon on the table. One of my mother's black-draped friends recited:

I have a rendezvous with Death
At some disputed barricade,
When spring comes back with rustling shade
And apple-blossoms fill the air—
I have a rendezvous with Death.²³

Most of the poets, they said, had been killed. The poetry made them dab their eyes with clean white handkerchiefs.

Next February, on my first birthday, there was a birthday cake with one candle. Lots of children and their elders. The war had been over two months and twenty-one days. "Why doesn't she smile?"

My brother was to blow out the candle. The elders were talking about the war and the political situation. Lloyd George and Asquith, Asquith and Lloyd George. I remembered recently having switched on to Mr. Asquith at a private party where he had been drinking a lot. He was playing cards, and when he came to cut the cards he tried to cut a large box of matches my mistake. On another occasion, I had seen him putting his arm around a lady's shoulder in a Daimler²⁴ motorcar, and generally behaving toward her in a very friendly fashion. Strangely enough, she said, "If you don't stop this nonsense immediately I'll order the chauffeur to stop and I'll get out." Mr. Asquith replied, "And pray, what reason will you give?"

¹⁸ The ruling family of Russia from 1613 to 1917.

¹⁹ A British philosopher, mathematician, and writer.

²⁰ Herbert Henry Asquith, prime minister of Britain from 1908 to 1916.

²¹ The agreement that marked the end of fighting in World War I.

²² David Lloyd George, prime minister of Britain from 1916 to 1922.

²³ The beginning of "I Have a Rendezvous with Death" by American poet Alan Seeger, who was killed in action during World War I.

²⁴ A German automobile-manufacturing company.

The guests arrived for my birthday. It was so sad, said one of the black widows, so sad about Wilfred Owen, who was killed so late in the war, and she quoted from a poem of his:

What passing-bells for these who dies as cattle?
Only the monstrous anger of the guns.²⁵

The children were squealing and toddling around. One was sick and another wet the floor and stood with his legs apart gaping at the puddle. All was mopped up. I banged my spoon on the table of my high chair. Someone was quoting:

But I've a rendezvous with Death
At midnight in some flaming town;
When spring trips north again this year,
And I to my pledged word am true,
I shall not fail that rendezvous.

More parents and children arrived. One stout man, who was warming his behind at the fire, said, "I always think those words of Asquith's after the Armistice were so apt..."

They brought the cake close to my high chair for me to see, with the candle shining and flickering above the pink icing. "A pity she never smiles," said one aunt.

"What Asquith told the House of Commons just after the war," said that stout gentleman with his backside to the fire, "—so apt, what Asquith said. He said that the war has cleansed and purged the world, by God! I recall his actual words: 'All things have become new. In this great cleansing and purging it has been the privilege of our country to play her part...'"

That did it. I broke into a decided smile, and everyone noticed it, convinced that it was provoked by the fact that my brother had blown out the candle on the cake. "She smiled!" my mother exclaimed. And everyone was clucking away about how I was smiling. For good measure, I crowed like a demented raven. "My baby's smiling!" said my mother.

"It was the candle on her cake," they said.

The cake be damned. Since that time I have grown to smile quite naturally, like any other healthy and house-trained person, but when I really mean a smile, deeply felt from the core, then to all intents and purposes it comes in response to the words uttered in the House of Commons after the First World War by the distinguished, the immaculately dressed, and the late Mr. Asquith.

²⁵ The beginning of Owen's "Anthem for Doomed Youth."